SUFFS

By Shaina Taub

Suggested Roles ***Actress 1:*** *SUFFS, Alice, Wilson, Mollie*
Actress 2: *SUFFS, Doris, Inez, Dudley, Alva, Lucy, Mrs. Herndon*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

SUFFS: (Pg 106-107) *(alternate lines between actresses)* How long must women wait for liberty? How many more marches in the streets? How many more efforts gone to waste? How many more deafening defeats? How many more histories erased? How many more Joans burned at the stake? How many more of us will it take? How long? How long til it's too late?

ALICE: Meet me at the White House gates at dawn!

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *This is the mostly forgotten tale of a handful of fearless females who fought for the right to vote.*
ACTRESS 2: *It's called the 19th Amendment, and even though the battle began with the Seneca Falls convention in 1848, the Constitutional amendment wasn't ratified until 1920.*
ACTRESS 1: *And even then, many women of color continued to be disenfranchised by literacy tests and discriminatory Jim Crow laws until The Voting Rights Act was passed in 1965.*
ACTRESS 2: *Today The Voting Rights Act is under review by the Supreme Court and old battles have become new again.*
ACTRESS 1: *Born from our nation's ugliest history — from the brutal struggles of those who fought for their Constitutional right to vote – 1848 to 1920 to 1965, people have fought for democratic representation.*
TOGETHER: *If voting rights are eroded for minorities, will the rights of women be far behind?*
ACTRESS 2: *Every character in this play provides an echo of the past.*
ACTRESS 1: *Just like us, they were living in an uncertain and hostile world. We tell their story because it is*
TOGETHER: Our *story*
ACTRESS 2: *And to remind ourselves that people, ordinary people, are capable of impacting our future.*
TOGETHER: *SUFFS by Shaina Taub*

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ALICE: **(Pg 18-19)** *(holding a protest sign)* I don't want to beg for crumbs from a country that doesn't care what I say. I don't want to be a meek little pawn in the games they play. I want to shout it out loud in the wide-open light 'til our generation has made things right. *(to Doris)* **(Pg 33-37)** Numbers?

DORIS: 26 floats, 9 brigades – a delegation from all 48 states. Representatives from 30 universities! 200,000 people attending . . . and Ida B Wells wrote to say she plans to march.

ALICE: Ida B Wells?!

DORIS: But . . . we've received letters from several southern doners threatening to pull out if colored women participate. Others say they must march in back . . ,.

ALICE: *(thinking)* Let's make a special colored delegation at the back of the line. No one pulls out. It'll all be fine. Without the southern women's support, there might be no march.

******The March*******

INEZ: **(Pg 44-45)** Mister President, hear our cry. We, the women of the country demand to be heard.

SUFFS: We demand to be heard!

INEZ: We demand to be seen

SUFFS: We demand to be seen!

INEZ: We demand a voice of our own

SUFFS: We demand an amendment!

TOGETHER: We demand an amendment!

DORIS: **(Pg 46-47)** But then a mob of sneering men storm the street!

SUFFS: Hundred of hooligans spit and jeer . . .

INEZ: **(Pg 48)** Listen up! If we all band together . . . Follow me! *(protest chant)* Get back. Make way. You're not stopping us today.

SUFFS*: (echo)* Get back. Make way.

*******The Oval Office******

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DORIS: **(Pg 65)** June 5, 1913, our first meeting with President Wilson

DUDLEY: **(Pg 63-64)** *(to President)* Sir. . . a committee is here from The National American Woman Suffrage Associa –

WILSON: Ah yes. The ladies. No one adores ladies more than I. When you're with ladies, you can enjoy your sacred duty as a man. *(Dudley moves to interject, but Wilson barrels on)* It isn't wise to weigh down women with the worries of the day. A female wants to focus on her family. *(to Dudley)* Send them in. *(Dudley exits)*

DUDLEY: **(Pg 75)** *(addressing the SUFFS)* I'm Dudley Malone . . . and you're the suffragettes?

DORIS: It's actually suffra-***gist***, not suffra-***gette***. Suffragette is what the papers all us to ake us seem like Kewpie dolls instead of legitimate reformers. One of their many tactics to diminish and disempower us.

ALICE: **(Pg 66)** *(SUFFS enter assertively)* Mister President, governments derive their just powers from the consent of the governed. Your administration has no right to legislate any reform without the consent of women!

DORIS: *(outraged)* **(Pg 53)** At the march, this old man called me a b****!

WILSON: **(Pg 64-65)** *(calmly, dismissively)* Ladies rely on us to supervise their lives. They require a man to manage their affairs. Why would ladies vote?

INEZ: **(Pg 44-45)** Mister President, demand to be heard.

WILSON: **(Pg 64-65)** *(continuing through the interruption)* We provide all that they need. If politics pollutes our ladies' lives, we'll sacrifice virility, and compromise fertility and threaten the stability of the USA. *(long tense pause)* **(Pg 68)** My chief of staff will escort you to the door. Dudley . . .

*****Later****

ALICE: **(Pg 84-85)** My fellow suffs, it's time to show Wilson that [we] are the vanguard of the future. *(chanting)* **VOTE WILSON OUT!**

SUFFS: VOTE WILSON OUT!

ALICE: Let's show Wilson that if he continues his hostility toward us, we're ready to. . .

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DORIS: (Pg 91) How will we do it when it's never been done?

ALICE: I want us to meet someone . . . A social-ite . . .

ALVA: (Pg 92-93) *(enters, she is obviously very wealthy, she introduces herself)* Alva Belmont. I divorced my husband for philandering, now I've got his millions for philanthropy.

ALICE: *(rushing to shake her hand)* I'm Alice Paul. We're starting a women's political party and we'd love for you to join it.

ALVA: You mean you'd live for me to ***fund*** it. *(beat)* Let me get this straight – you gals just declared political warfare on Wilson and his party and now you shamelessly demand my riches for this risky rebel coup. The nerve *(a tense beat)* I LOVE it. To whom do I make out the check?

*******Months Later before the White House gates*******

The SUFFS are standing in silent protest, blocking the gate to the White House.

DORIS: (Pg 109) I won't forget that frigid January morning when my heart was in my stomach at the president's front door.

MOLLIE: (Pg 110-111) It looks like people are blocking the entrance to the White House.

DUDLEY: *(to someone trying to enter)* Unfortunately, the president must postpone your meeting indefinitely. Since early this morning, the National Woman's Party has been keeping a silent vigil at the gates. They're refusing to leave until the president endorses suffrage.

SUFFS: (Pg 112) *(actresses should alternate lines)* And what started as a dozen turned to hundreds within weeks. Though not a word was spoken, our volume only grew.

DORIS: (Pg 113) April 6th, 1917, Wilson declares war on Germany.

ALICE: *(reading the paper, she quotes Wilson)* "It is a fearful thing to lead our country into war, ***but we must fight for democracy."*** *(with an idea)* Let's put Wilson's words on our banners. Show how hypocritical he is to fight for democracy abroad while denying it to us here at home.

LUCY: (Pg 114-115) But wait – it also says – "Any citizen who makes unpatriotic statements shall be punished.

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ALICE: I could feel us start to panic,

SUFFS: *(actresses should alternate lines)* But then suddenly we felt it – every cost and battle lost of every generation past. So we rose up in defiance. We chose to risk it all for our sisters' silent voices. Let the patriarchy fall!

(sirens as unseen policemen and onlookers close in on the SUFFS and they are all arrested)

*******In the Oval Office*******

DUDLEY: **(Pg 116-117)** *(enters with urgency)* Mister President, something terrible has happened. I just witnessed the trial of the National Women's Party pickets. The judge sentenced them to six months in prison for "obstructing traffic." Sir, surely you agree this is some kind of grievous mistake.

WILSON: Well, this is the first I'm hearing of the suffragette situation.

DUDLEY: But I was standing right here when you ordered their arrest. And it's suffra-***gist***, not suffra-***gette***. Perhaps a pardon is in order?

WILSON: Those girls' banners are treasonous.

DUDLEY: Does quoting the president amount to treason? **(Pg 118)** *(beat, then with passion)* It is high time that men of this generation stood up in support of the women of this country. If men had been peacefully demanding our right to vote for over half a century, if men had been repeatedly ignored or met with evasion by Congress; you would understand and forgive their righteous indignation.

WILSON: Come on, now Dudley. Be a man! *(exits)*

*******Occoquan Prison *******

MRS. HERNDON: **(Pgs 120-121)** Inmates! This is ***my*** prison mess hall. You will sit down, shut up and eat your food.

ALICE: But, we're political prisoners and we refuse . . .

MRS. HERNDON: *(interrupting)* Political prisoners? Ain't no such thing in America. Guards, if ona-a these girls says another damn word, knock her teeth out. Now eat!

ALICE: Hunger strike! **(Pg 124)** Wilson will be shamed into a pardon as soon as word gets out he's letting women die of starvation.

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*******Press Conference and Occoquan Prison *******

DR. WHITE: (Pg 133-136) Mister President, I have the report on the conditions in the prison. This ought to debunk all the baseless claims that the women are being mistreated

WILSON: *(reads report aloud at a press conference)* We are providing the ladies with excellent care.

DORIS: A doctor came and dragged me out of my bed.

WILSON: Their treatment includes artificial feeding.

DORIS: We are forcibly fed three times a day.

WILSON: The ladies receive it without resistance. There is no force necessary.

DORIS: They pry my mouth open with pliers, and I try to clench my teeth shut but they shove the tube down my throat, up my nose.

WILSON: The ladies are offered fresh milk and eggs.

LUCY: They pour raw eggs through the tube to my gut.

WILSON: They experience no discomfort, and all rumors in the press of physical abuse are entirely false.

LUCY: They withdrew the tube and I bled out my nose, out my mouth, so much blood. *(beat)* They took Alice away. Have not seen her in days . . .

WILSON: *(to Dr. White an order disguised as a suggestion)* Someone ought to commit her to an asylum.

DR. WHITE: She does exhibit symptoms of hysteria, such as verbal displays of opinions in public. **(Pg 137)** *(to Alice)* Sane women do not starve themselves to prove a point. If you refuse to eat, I shall sign the president's order for you to permanently committed to St. Elizabeth's Asylum.

ALICE: *(non-verbally responds in defiance, Dr. exits; she speaks to audience)* **(Pg 140)** Is it so insane to want my own choice? Wouldn't you be hysterical if you had no voice?

*******Presidential Address to Congress *******

WILSON: (Pg 147) Let it be known that the voices of foolish agitators in the streets did

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not reach me at all. Rather it was the voices of patriotic ladies whose service lies at the heart of the war. I know that heart will beat stronger if you give them this . . .thing.

DORIS: *(to audience)* Fun fact! He actually said that.

WILSON: Thank you and God bless America. *(off the podium and away from cameras, he drops the façade)* Oh, please. Passing the amendment through Congress means nothing. Convince 36 states to ratify it! The south will never let ladies vote, let alone colored ladies, thank God!

SUFFS: **(Pg 170)** *(alternate lines between actresses)* The world ***can*** be changed. So keep marching, keep marching. Let history sound the alarm of how the future demands that we fight for it ***now***. Progress is possible, not guaranteed.

TOGETHER: Keep marching!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Shaina Taub
ISBN: 978-1636702261
Publisher: Theatre Communications Group
Date (Month/Year): Nov 2024

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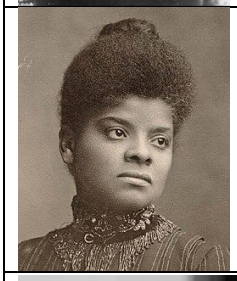
Historical Figures



Alice Paul *left the National American Woman Suffrage Association (NAWSA) because of a fundamental disagreement over strategy and a belief that NAWSA's methods were too conservative and slow. She advocated for a more aggressive approach focused on lobbying Congress for a federal constitutional amendment, while NAWSA prioritized a state-by-state campaign. This led her to form the National Woman's Party (NWP) to pursue her more radical vision, which included direct confrontation and protests.*



Doris Stevens *organized party delegates for each of the 435 Congressional districts in an effort to achieve nationwide enfranchisement for women. She also participated in the Silent Sentinels vigils outside the White House from 1917 – 1919, a protest aimed at forcing the passage of a constitutional amendment for women's voting rights. Stevens was arrested on multiple occasions and wrote a memoir in 1920, Jailed for Freedom, outlining the struggle. Once voting rights for women had been achieved, Stevens turned her attention to the legal status of women and fought for the Equal Rights Amendment.*



Ida B. Wells *was fighting a bigger battle — against sexism and racism — and faced obstacles within their own movement. She took part in the first suffragist parade in Washington, D.C., in 1913, which was organized by the National American Woman Suffrage Association, as the sole Black woman in the Illinois delegation. Wells marched with this group despite being asked at the last moment to move to the back of the procession with the segregated contingent.*



Alva Belmont *was the most important financial benefactor among the leaders of the Congressional Union for Woman Suffrage (CU) and its successor organization, the National Woman's Party (NWP).*



Inez Milholland *is best known for leading the 1913 women's suffrage parade in Washington, D.C., dressed in a flowing white cloak and crown and riding a white horse. She was a talented speaker and a passionate advocate for women's rights, socialism, and pacifism.*



Lucy Burns*, tall and red-haired with bright blue eyes, was a fierce fighter in the cause for woman suffrage. She carried a banner emblazoned with the slogan shown above when she led a procession of women through a train yard in 1919. All the women had served time in jail for protesting in support of woman suffrage. The women of the "Prison Special" railroad tour of the country wore drab, baggy dresses similar to the uniforms they were forced to wear when they were imprisoned. It was fitting that Lucy led them, since she had spent more time in prison than any other American woman suffragist.*

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